MODULE 01 · FOUNDATIONS - ALL DOMAINS

The 2026 PMP and the PMBOK 8 map

What the exam outline tests, how the new PMBOK Guide is organised, and how the two fit together.

DOMAIN Foundations EXAM WEIGHT All domains MODULE 01 of 49

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The outline is the **syllabus**. The PMBOK Guide is the **textbook**.

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How the exam outline is built

01

Domain

A broad area of practice. Three of them, each with a fixed weight.

02

Task

A responsibility of the project manager. Twenty-six in total.

03

Enabler

An example of the work inside a task. Illustrative, not a complete list.

ON THE EXAM

Every exam form covers every task. Nothing on the outline is safe to skip.

Domain I – People: eight tasks

#	TASK	IN ONE LINE
1	Develop a common vision	Everyone understands the same goal, and it stays current
2	Manage conflicts	Find the source, agree a resolution, keep ground rules alive
3	Lead the project team	Set expectations, empower, solve problems, pick a leadership style
4	Engage stakeholders	Identify, analyse, tailor communication, build trust
5	Align stakeholder expectations	Categorise, surface expectations, facilitate agreement, mentor
6	Manage stakeholder expectations	Internal and external customers, satisfaction over time
7	Help ensure knowledge transfer	Identify critical knowledge, gather it, make sharing normal
8	Plan and manage communication	Strategy, transparency, feedback loops, reporting

ON THE EXAM

Stakeholders and communication now live here. In 2021 they were Process tasks.

Domain II - Process: ten tasks

#	TASK	IN ONE LINE
1	Integrated plan and plan delivery	Choose the approach, build and maintain one integrated plan
2	Develop and manage scope	Define it, agree it, break it down
3	Help ensure value-based delivery	Prioritise by value, deliver incrementally, track benefits
4	Plan and manage resources	Plan them from requirements, optimise availability
5	Plan and manage procurement	Contract types, negotiation, supplier performance
6	Plan and manage finance	Budgets, reserves, spend tracking, financial reporting
7	Plan and optimise quality	Quality requirements, compliance, cost of quality
8	Plan and manage schedule	Estimate, baseline, analyse variation
9	Evaluate project status	Metrics, artefacts, progress, status reporting
10	Manage project closure	Acceptance, transition readiness, closing activities

ON THE EXAM

Value-based delivery is a Process task now, not a Business Environment one.

Domain III - Business Environment: eight tasks

#	TASK	IN ONE LINE
1	Define and establish governance	Structure, rules, ethics, success metrics, escalation paths
2	Plan and manage compliance	Security, safety, sustainability, regulation
3	Manage and control changes	Run the change process, communicate, update records
4	Remove impediments, manage issues	Clear blockers, spot when a risk has become an issue
5	Plan and manage risk	Identify, analyse, respond, monitor, communicate
6	Continuous improvement	Use lessons learned, update process assets
7	Support organisational change	Assess culture, plan for the impact of change
8	Evaluate external changes	Regulation, technology, geopolitics, markets

ON THE EXAM

Governance, change, issues and risk moved here. That is most of the jump from 8% to 26%.

Where the 2021 tasks went

MOVED INTO PEOPLE

Relationship work

- Manage communications
- Engage stakeholders
- Knowledge transfer

MOVED INTO BUSINESS ENV.

Control and context

- Governance structure
- Risks, changes, issues
- Impediments and blockers
- Continuous improvement

THE TIEBREAKER

If older material files a topic elsewhere, the judgement is the same. Only the domain label moved.

How the PMBOK Guide 8th Edition is built

01

6 principles

How you think. They guide behaviour.

02

7 domains

Where you focus. Areas of practice.

03

5 focus areas

When. Initiating through closing.

04

40 processes

What you do. Illustrative, not mandatory.

05

Tailoring

Fit all of it to the context.

ON THE EXAM

Principles are how you think. Domains are where you look. Processes are what you might do.

The six principles, and how they show up in answers

PRINCIPLE	IN AN EXAM ANSWER, IT LOOKS LIKE
Adopt a holistic view	Considering the knock-on effects before acting on one symptom
Focus on value	Choosing the option that delivers outcomes, not just outputs
Embed quality into processes and deliverables	Preventing defects rather than inspecting them out
Be an accountable leader	Owning the problem instead of passing it up the line
Integrate sustainability within all project areas	Weighing environmental, social and economic impact
Build an empowered culture	Letting the team decide how to do the work

THE TIEBREAKER

When two answers both work, the one that honours more of these principles usually wins.

Two principles that are new in spirit

- **Integrate sustainability** is new as a core principle. It also appears in the outline's planning, quality, compliance and risk tasks.
- It means more than the environment: social and economic effects count, over the life of the product.
- **Be an accountable leader** sharpens the old stewardship idea: accountability for outcomes, not just for activity.
- Passing a decision up to the sponsor because it is uncomfortable is not accountability.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Sustainability is no longer a niche topic. Expect it inside ordinary planning and risk questions.

The seven performance domains

DOMAIN	PROCESSES	ABSORBED FROM OLDER EDITIONS
Governance	9	Integration, plus parts of quality and the sourcing strategy
Scope	6	Scope, requirements, and the rest of quality
Schedule	3	Schedule, with four old processes merged into one
Finance	4	Cost, widened to funding and value
Stakeholders	7	Stakeholder engagement and communications, now together
Resources	5	Team and physical resources
Risk	6	Risk, with the two analysis processes merged

ON THE EXAM

Communications and stakeholders are one domain now. Procurement detail moved to an appendix.

Five focus areas: the old process groups, renamed

01

Initiating

Authorise, set direction, identify stakeholders.

02

Planning

Decide how. Half of the forty processes live here.

03

Executing

Do the work, lead the team, engage people.

04

Monitoring and controlling

Compare, correct, manage change.

05

Closing

Accept, transfer, learn, release.

ON THE EXAM

In agile work the focus areas repeat every iteration. They are not a one-way waterfall.

Translating older terms

IN OLDER MATERIAL	IN PMBOK 8
Process groups	Focus areas
Ten knowledge areas	Seven performance domains
Collect requirements	Elicit and analyze requirements
Define activities, sequence, estimate durations, develop schedule	Develop schedule, one process
Qualitative and quantitative risk analysis	Perform risk analysis, one process
Develop team and manage team	Lead the team
Control costs	Monitor and control finances

ON THE EXAM

The exam tests the thinking, not the process names. Recognise both vocabularies and move on.

A project is a temporary initiative in a unique context, undertaken **to create value**.

Two kinds of success

PROJECT MANAGEMENT SUCCESS

Delivered as planned

- On time
- Within budget
- Agreed scope
- Required quality

PROJECT SUCCESS

Worth the effort

- Stakeholders see the value
- Intended outcomes achieved
- Worth the time and money spent
- Judged by the people it serves

THE TIEBREAKER

A project can hit every baseline and still fail. PMI now asks you to own both kinds of success.

M.O.R.E.: how PMI says you get project success

01

Manage perceptions

Value must be seen by stakeholders, not just delivered.

02

Own project success

Accountable for value, beyond managing tasks.

03

Relentlessly reassess

Revisit goals and parameters as things change.

04

Expand perspective

See the organisation and the wider world.

ON THE EXAM

These four habits sit behind many 'what should the project manager do' answers.

From outputs to value

01

Output

The thing produced: an app, a building, a policy.

›

02

Outcome

The change it makes possible: faster booking.

›

03

Benefit

The measurable gain: fewer missed appointments.

›

04

Value

Worth to the organisation and its people.

ON THE EXAM

An output nobody uses produces no outcome. Plan and measure all the way to the right.

Tailoring: nothing is compulsory

- Every principle, process and artefact is **adapted to the context**: size, risk, approach, culture, regulation.
- Tailoring is done deliberately, with the people involved, and revisited as the project learns.
- Using every template 'because it exists' is not good practice. Neither is skipping governance 'because we are agile'.
- Organisational rules still apply. Tailor within them, and propose changes through the right route.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The best answer usually adapts the process to the project, with agreement, rather than obeying or ignoring it.

How to use the PMBOK Guide for this exam

- Learn the **ideas** behind each domain and principle, well enough to apply them to a story.
- Do not memorise inputs, tools and outputs. The exam does not ask for them.
- Read the Agile Practice Guide alongside it. Sixty percent of items are agile or hybrid.
- Keep the **outline's task list** as your checklist. That is what is weighted and scored.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Study to apply, not to recite. Every question is a situation, not a definition.

Project Lantern on the map

- **People:** a booking-app team, six clinic managers, patients, a regulator, a hardware supplier.
- **Process:** a hybrid plan, a product backlog, a fixed-price hardware contract, a budget with reserves.
- **Business Environment:** health-data rules, a steering committee, new clinic workflows, a supplier facing tariffs.
- One project touches all three domains every week. So do exam questions.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Real questions blend domains. Name the main one, but expect the others in the background.

A project to introduce a new expense-claims system finished on time and under budget. Every requirement in the scope statement was accepted.

Three weeks later, most staff are still emailing paper forms to finance. The sponsor thanks the project manager and asks them to close the project so the team can move on.

What should the project manager do?

A Close the project, because every baseline and acceptance criterion was met.

B Raise a change request to add the features users have asked for.

C Record the low adoption in the lessons learned and archive the project.

D Assess with the sponsor why adoption is low, and agree how the intended benefits will be secured.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Close the project.

Project management success only. The outputs exist, but the outcome has not happened.

B Raise a change request.

Jumps to a solution before anyone knows why people are not adopting it.

C Record it and archive.

Documents the failure instead of acting while there is still time to fix it.

D Assess with the sponsor, agree how benefits are secured.

Owns project success: finds the cause and protects the value, with the sponsor.

THE SIGNAL

Baselines met, value missing. The exam wants you to own the outcome, not just the output.

> A PMO requires every project to complete its full set of predictive templates, including a detailed schedule baseline and monthly earned value reports.
>
> A project manager is starting a six-week internal project. A small team will build a reporting tool, and the users want to see working versions every week and change priorities as they learn.

What should the project manager do?

A Complete every PMO template as required, then run weekly demonstrations on top.

B Propose a tailored approach to the PMO that meets its governance needs with lighter agile artefacts.

C Skip the templates, because agile projects do not need that documentation.

D Ask the sponsor to exempt the project from PMO requirements.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A. Complete every template, add demos.

Heavy overhead for six weeks, and a fixed baseline fights the changing priorities.

B. Propose a tailored approach to the PMO.

Adapts the process to the context, with agreement, while respecting governance.

C. Skip the templates.

Ignores a real organisational rule. Agile still needs governance and records.

D. Ask the sponsor for an exemption.

Goes around the PMO instead of working with it, and assumes all or nothing.

THE SIGNAL

The rule does not fit the project. Tailor it, openly and through the right route.

Know the outline's tasks. Think in principles. Tailor everything else.

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